POLYTECHNIQUE MONTRÉAL
affiliée à l'Université de Montréal

A lightweight canonicalization engine in C

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Mémoire présenté en vue de l'obtention du diplôme de *Maîtrise ès sciences appliquées*
Electrical Engineering

July 2026

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Ce mémoire intitulé :

A lightweight canonicalization engine in C

présenté par **William ZHANG**
en vue de l'obtention du diplôme de *Maîtrise ès sciences appliquées*
a été dûment accepté par le jury d'examen constitué de :

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DEDICATION

À tous mes amis du labos,
vous me manquerez...

ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

Texte / Text.

RÉSUMÉ

Le résumé est un bref exposé du sujet traité, des objectifs visés, des hypothèses émises, des méthodes expérimentales utilisées et de l'analyse des résultats obtenus. On y présente également les principales conclusions de la recherche ainsi que ses applications éventuelles. En général, un résumé ne dépasse pas trois pages.

Le résumé doit donner une idée exacte du contenu du mémoire ou de la thèse. Ce ne peut pas être une simple énumération des parties du manuscrit. Le but est de présenter de façon précise et concise la nature, l'envergure de la recherche, les sujets traités, les questions de recherche ou les hypothèses soulevées, les méthodes utilisées, les principaux résultats ainsi que les conclusions retenues. Un résumé ne doit jamais comporter de références ou de figures.

ABSTRACT

Written in English, the abstract is a brief summary similar to the previous section (Résumé). However, this section is not a word for word translation of the abstract in French.

The abstract is a brief statement of the subject matter, objectives, research questions or hypotheses, experimental methods and analysis of results. It also presents the main research conclusions and their possible applications. In general, an abstract should not exceed three pages.

The abstract should provide an exact idea of the thesis or dissertation's contents and it cannot be a simple enumeration of the manuscript's parts. The goal is to precisely and concisely present the nature and scope of the research. An abstract should never include references or figures. If the thesis or the dissertation is in English, the résumé (French-language abstract) should come first followed by the abstract.

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LIST OF SYMBOLS AND ACRONYMS

AD	Automatic Differentiation
AML	Algebraic Modeling Language
CSC	Compressed Sparse Column
CSR	Compressed Sparse Row
DAG	Directed Acyclic Graph
DCP	Disciplined Convex Programming
LP	Linear Program
MOI	MathOptInterface
MPS	Mathematical Programming System
NLP	Nonlinear Program
QP	Quadratic Program
SOCP	Second-Order Cone Program
SDP	Semidefinite Program

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CHAPTER 1 INTRODUCTION

Convex optimization modeling languages such as CVXPY [**?**] and YALMIP [**?**] let users specify optimization problems in a natural mathematical syntax. Under the hood, these tools *canonicalize* the user's problem into a standard form that a solver can accept, *e.g.*,

$$\begin{array}{ll} \text{minimize} & c^T x \\ \text{subject to} & Ax + s = b \\ & s \in K, \end{array} \tag{1.1}$$

where $x \in \mathbf{R}^n$ and $s \in \mathbf{R}^m$ are decision variables, $A \in \mathbf{R}^{m \times n}$, $b \in \mathbf{R}^m$, $c \in \mathbf{R}^n$ are problem data, and $K \subseteq \mathbf{R}^m$ is a convex cone. The final step of canonicalization—converting a symbolic expression tree into the explicit matrices A, b, c—is called *matrix stuffing* (or *coefficient extraction*).

The bottleneck. Most research in convex optimization focuses on improving solvers, but the modeling layer can itself become the bottleneck. In CVXPY, matrix stuffing is implemented in pure Python: it walks the expression tree, allocates many intermediate sparse matrices, and assembles them into A, b, and c. For large problems this step dominates wall-clock time. The overhead limits the practicality of modeling languages for large-scale problem instances.

Problem statement. Every modeling language must ultimately form the numerical problem data (A, b, c) before handing them to a solver. In CVXPY, this coefficient extraction step is the most computationally expensive part of the modeling pipeline—largely because Python's interpreter overhead and repeated memory allocations dominate for large inputs. The goal of this work is to replace the inner loop with compiled C code, making matrix stuffing significantly faster and more memory-efficient so that the modeling layer is no longer the bottleneck.

Contributions. We make the following contributions:

1. We develop `SparseDiffEngine`, a lightweight C library that performs coefficient extraction via direct CSR construction, avoiding the intermediate sparse matrices created by CVXPY's Python code.

2. We develop `SparseDiffPy`, a Python wrapper for `SparseDiffEngine` that integrates directly with CVXPY as a drop-in replacement for its matrix stuffing module.

3. We benchmark the resulting system against CVXPY's default implementation and demonstrate substantial improvements in both runtime and memory usage.

All code is open source and available at `https://github.com/SparseDifferentiation/`.

Thesis outline. The rest of this thesis is organized as follows. Chapter 2 reviews the literature on modeling languages, canonicalization, and matrix stuffing. Chapter 3 describes our proposed coefficient extraction engine and its design. Chapter 4 presents benchmark results comparing our method to existing approaches. Chapter 6 summarizes our findings and discusses future work.

CHAPTER 2 LITERATURE REVIEW

Solving an optimization problem on a computer requires translating the mathematical formulation into a data format that solvers can process. For linear programs, this means constructing the constraint matrix A, the right-hand side vector b, and the objective coefficients c that define the *standard form*,

$$\begin{aligned} \text{minimize} \quad & c^T x \\ \text{subject to} \quad & Ax \leq b, \\ & x \geq 0. \end{aligned} \tag{2.1}$$

Manual encoding In the early days of linear programming, analysts manually computed and encoded each coefficient onto punch cards. This process was tedious, error-prone and became impractical as linear programming found more and more applications in large-scale industrial problems [1].

MPS format IBM's Mathematical Programming System (MPS) file format, developed in the 1960s, established a standardized file format for representing linear programs [2]. The MPS format uses fixed-width fields designed for 80-column punch cards, with sections for rows, columns, and coefficients. William Orchard-Hays [3] provides a comprehensive history of these early mathematical programming systems, tracing their development from 1952 at RAND Corporation through their widespread adoption on mainframe computers in the late 1960s.

Matrix generators To automate the creation of MPS files, *matrix generators* emerged in the late 1960s; they are procedural programs that compute the problem coefficients through explicit loops and output the results in MPS format [4]. Commercial systems such as `MaGen` [5], `GAMMA` [6], and `DATAFORM` [7] were among the first matrix generators which were used in various domains.

2.1 Canonicalization

Disciplined convex programming (DCP) [8, 9] is a set of composition rules that can automatically verify convexity. A DCP language restricts how atoms (elementary functions with known curvature) may be combined: for example, a convex function of an affine expression

is convex, but a convex function of a convex expression is not necessarily so. By enforcing these rules at problem construction time, DCP languages guarantee that any accepted formulation is convex and can be reduced to conic standard form. The DCP approach was first implemented in `CVX` [10] for MATLAB and has since been adopted by `CVXPY` [11, 12] in Python, `CVXR` [13] in R, and `Convex.jl` [14] in Julia. This section focuses on `CVXPY`, the system targeted by the coefficient extraction engine developed in this thesis.

`CVXPY` is a domain-specific language for convex optimization embedded in Python. It was originally developed by Steven Diamond and Stephen Boyd at Stanford University [11]. Akshay Agrawal later redesigned the rewriting system in `CVXPY` [12], which enabled support for other disciplined languages [15–17]. The project has since grown through contributions from many other developers and solver interface maintainers.

Reduction-based rewriting `CVXPY` is built on a system of *reductions* [12]. A reduction is a pair of maps: a *forward* map that transforms a problem into an equivalent one, and a *backward* map that recovers a solution of the original problem from a solution of the transformed one. Reductions compose: the output of one becomes the input of the next, forming a *chain* that converts the user's formulation into solver-ready data.

The chain is solver-aware, so different solvers trigger different output formats. Historically, `CVXPY` distinguished two standard forms. For solvers that accept quadratic objectives such as `OSQP` and `Gurobi`, the chain produces a quadratic program:

$$\begin{array}{ll} \text{minimize} & \frac{1}{2}\, x^T P\, x + c^T x \\ \text{subject to} & l \leq Ax \leq u. \end{array} \tag{2.2}$$

For purely conic solvers (*e.g.*`SCS`), the chain instead produces:

$$\begin{array}{ll} \text{minimize} & c^T x \\ \text{subject to} & Ax + b \in \mathcal{K}. \end{array} \tag{2.3}$$

More recently, a unified interface that combines a quadratic objective with conic constraints has become the central solver interface in `CVXPY`:

$$\begin{array}{ll} \text{minimize} & \frac{1}{2}\, x^T P\, x + c^T x \\ \text{subject to} & Ax + b \in \mathcal{K}. \end{array} \tag{2.4}$$

In all cases the final output is a set of sparse coefficient matrices; what changes between reduction paths is the *structure* of those matrices.

Common reductions The individual reductions that compose a canonicalization chain are well established in the convex optimization literature. Chu et al. [18] give a concise exposition; the main steps are:

1. **DCP verification.** Confirm that the objective is convex and the constraints are valid by walking the expression tree and applying DCP composition rules.
2. **Smith form.** Replace each subexpression with a new auxiliary variable linked to the original expression by an equality constraint.
3. **Relaxed Smith form.** Relax the equalities introduced above to inequalities wherever the monotonicity of the objective guarantees that the inequality will be tight at optimality.
4. **Matrix stuffing.** Assemble the resulting affine expressions into sparse coefficient matrices before passing them to a solver.

The following sections examine how these steps—and in particular the final matrix-stuffing step—are implemented in practice across different systems.

Other reductions `CVXPY` also ships reductions beyond the standard canonicalization chain. For example, a *flip-objective* reduction converts a maximization problem into a minimization, and the `Dgp2Dcp` reduction rewrites disciplined geometric programs into equivalent disciplined convex programs [15].

2.2 Sparse matrix formats

The coefficient matrices produced by canonicalization are typically large but sparse: only a small fraction of the entries are nonzero. Storing and operating on these matrices efficiently requires specialised *sparse matrix formats* that record only the nonzero entries and their positions. Three formats dominate the optimisation toolchain; they differ in how they encode the row and column structure, and this difference has direct consequences for the operations that are efficient in each format.

COO (Coordinate) The simplest sparse format stores each nonzero as a triple (i, j, v): row index, column index, and value. For a matrix with `nnz` nonzeros, three arrays of length `nnz` suffice. COO is convenient for incremental construction—appending an entry is $O(1)$—but accessing a specific row or column requires scanning the entire list.

CSR (Compressed Sparse Row) CSR groups entries by row. It stores three arrays:

- `indptr` (length $m + 1$): `indptr[i]` is the index into `indices` and `data` where row i begins.
- `indices` (length `nnz`): the column index of each nonzero.
- `data` (length `nnz`): the corresponding values.

Row i occupies positions `indptr[i]` through `indptr[i+1] - 1`. This layout makes row slicing, row iteration, and matrix–vector products $y = Ax$ efficient, since each row's entries are contiguous in memory.

CSC (Compressed Sparse Column) CSC is the column-oriented analogue of CSR: entries are grouped by column, with an `indptr` array of length $n + 1$ indexing into `indices` (row indices) and `data`. Column slicing and $y = A^T x$ products are fast. CSC is the default format in `SciPy` and the input format expected by most conic solvers [19, 20].

Format choice in coefficient extraction During matrix stuffing, the extraction engine builds the constraint matrix A row by row: each constraint contributes one or more rows. CSR is the natural format for this construction pattern, since rows can be filled sequentially without touching other rows. A final CSR-to-CSC conversion is needed only at the solver interface. The extraction engine developed in this thesis operates entirely in CSR during construction and converts to CSC only at the end.

2.3 Matrix stuffing

After canonicalization reduces a convex problem to a collection of affine constraints, the final step before invoking a solver is *matrix stuffing*: assembling the numerical coefficients of these affine expressions into the sparse matrices (A, b, c) that solvers consume. Each canonicalized constraint is an affine function of the decision variable x, and the task is to extract its coefficients into the appropriate rows of the constraint matrix A and the right-hand side b.

The operation is conceptually straightforward—read off the coefficients of each affine expression—but in practice the expressions are represented as trees of composed linear operations, and the coefficients must be extracted by traversing these trees. The cost of this traversal depends on how the composition is carried out: naive approaches perform a sparse matrix–matrix multiplication at each node, while structure-aware approaches can exploit the known form of each operation to avoid unnecessary work.

This section illustrates how `CVXPY` implements matrix stuffing via sparse linear map composition, using expression trees as the central data structure.

Expression trees After canonicalization, `CVXPY` guarantees that all constraints and the objective are affine functions of the decision variable x. Each affine function is represented as an *expression tree* where every node is a linear operation (an *atom*), as illustrated in Figure 2.1.

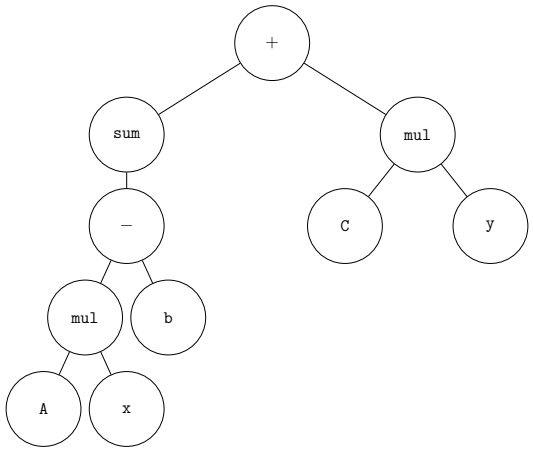


Figure 2.1 Expression tree for the affine expression `sum(A @ x - b) + C @ y`. Each internal node is an affine atom; leaves are variables or constants.

When a problem involves matrix variables, `CVXPY` flattens them into vectors using column-major (Fortran) ordering: $X \in \mathbf{R}^{m\times n}$ becomes $(X_{11}, X_{21}, \ldots, X_{m1}, X_{12}, \ldots, X_{mn})^T \in \mathbf{R}^{mn}$. This convention determines the column ordering in all coefficient matrices.

Matrix stuffing via sparse linear map composition The extraction phase traverses each expression tree bottom-up. Each leaf node returns its coefficient matrix (the identity for a variable, a constant matrix for data), and each internal node composes its children's matrices by applying its own linear operator. The composition is carried out via sparse matrix multiplication.

For example, in the expression `sum(A @ x)`, the traversal first returns I at the variable node, multiplies by A at the `mul` node to get A, then multiplies by $\mathbf{1}^T$ at the `sum` node to get $\mathbf{1}^T A$ (Figure 2.2). Each step performs a sparse matrix–matrix product and allocates a new result matrix.

Architecture of the extraction backends Internally, `CVXPY` represents the canonicalized tree as a list of `LinOp` nodes. The extraction is handled by a `PythonCanonBackend` whose

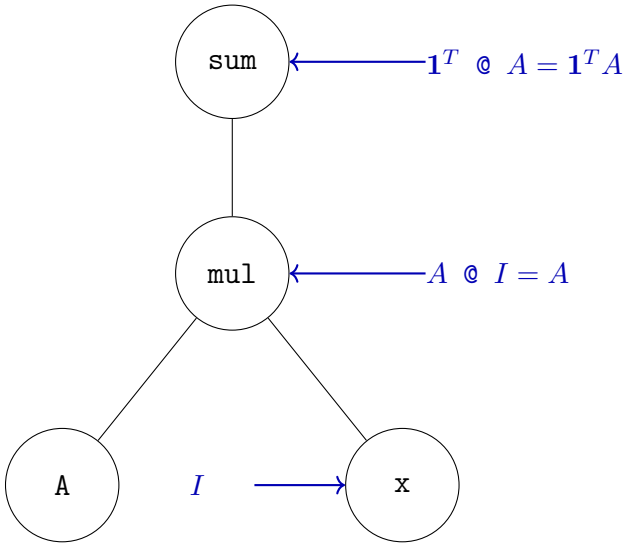


Figure 2.2 Coefficient matrix accumulation for `sum(A @ x)`. Each node composes its operator with the child's coefficient matrix via sparse matrix multiplication, producing a new intermediate matrix at every step.

`build_matrix` method walks each tree and returns a 2D sparse matrix. The central data structure is a `TensorView`: a dictionary mapping each variable to its coefficient block (a sparse matrix). A recursive function `process_constraint` traverses the tree bottom-up, applying the appropriate linear operator at each node.

The operations performed during this traversal fall into three categories:

1. **Pure index operations** (`reshape`, `transpose`, `index`, `promote`, `broadcast_to`). These only remap row indices—no arithmetic is performed. Essentially free in terms of floating-point cost.

2. **Elementwise operations** (`neg`, `mul_elem`, `div`). These scale existing entries via elementwise multiplication. The sparsity pattern is unchanged.

3. **Matrix multiplication operations** (`mul`, `rmul`, `sum_entries`, `conv`, `kron`). These build an explicit operator matrix and apply it via general-purpose `scipy.sparse @ scipy.sparse`. *This is where the cost lives.*

Detailed example: left multiplication Consider the node `C @ X` where $C \in \mathbf{R}^{m \times n}$ is a constant and $X \in \mathbf{R}^{n \times p}$ is the child expression. The vectorised form is $\mathbf{vec}(CX) = (I_p \otimes C)\ \mathbf{vec}(X)$, so the backend builds the Kronecker product $I_p \otimes C$ via `sp.kron(sp.eye(p), C)`, applies it to the child's coefficient matrix via sparse matrix multiplication, and converts

the result to CSR. This sequence involves three allocations per node: the Kronecker product, the matrix product, and the format conversion.

What is already exploited `CVXPY`'s implementation does exploit some structure. Index operations are handled as pure reindexing without forming operator matrices. Elementwise operations use `.multiply()` instead of matrix multiplication. The Kronecker structure is partially exploited by using `sp.kron(sp.eye(n), C)` rather than materialising a dense matrix.

What is not exploited Several opportunities for efficiency remain:

- The Kronecker operator $I_p \otimes C$ is materialised as a general sparse matrix, even though its block-diagonal structure means C could be applied independently to p blocks.
- Sparsity patterns are discovered at runtime by `SciPy`'s sparse arithmetic, even though they are fully determinable from the expression structure at build time.
- No pre-allocation of the final output is possible, since each intermediate product has an independently computed sparsity pattern.
- General-purpose sparse matrix multiplication is used regardless of the known structure of the operator (diagonal scaling, row selection, Kronecker with identity, *etc.*).

`CVXPY` ships two Python backends (SciPy-based and COO-based) as well as a legacy C++ backend (`cvxcore`) that special-cases eighteen `LinOp` types. All three share the same compositional architecture.

Key advantage of the deferred approach Unlike `JuMP`'s eager expansion, the deferred approach preserves the original problem structure through canonicalization. The expression `norm(F @ x - g)` never forms F^TF; the matrix F appears directly in the coefficient data. This structural preservation is what enables conic reformulations that exploit the original factors.

2.4 Coefficient extraction

Different systems take different approaches to extracting coefficient data from optimization formulations. To make the comparison concrete, we trace a running example through each

system: the least-squares problem

$$\text{minimize} \quad \|Fx - g\|_2^2, \tag{2.5}$$

with $F \in \mathbf{R}^{3\times 2}$ and $g \in \mathbf{R}^3$.

`JuMP` and `MathOptInterface` `JuMP` [21,22] is an algebraic modeling language embedded in Julia. Its abstraction layer, `MathOptInterface` [23], represents each constraint as a *function-set pair*: a mathematical function paired with the set it must belong to. This function-in-set architecture uses operator overloading to eagerly build coefficient representations. There is no expression tree and no deferred extraction phase—the coefficients *are* the internal representation. The following trace shows how this works for the least-squares problem (2.5).

Step 1: Macro expansion. The user writes:

```
using JuMP, MosekTools
F = [1 2; 3 4; 5 6]; g = [1, 2, 3]
model = Model(Mosek.Optimizer)
@variable(model, x[1:2])
@objective(model, Min, sum((F * x - g).^2))
```

The `@objective` macro expands `sum((F * x - g) .^ 2)` by evaluating each subexpression eagerly. The product `F * x` dispatches through Julia's linear algebra: each element $r_i = F_{i1}x_1 + F_{i2}x_2 - g_i$ is built as a `ScalarAffineFunction` containing the coefficients F_{i1}, F_{i2} and the constant $-g_i$ explicitly.

Step 2: Quadratic function construction. Squaring each residual r_i^2 triggers `JuMP`'s multiplication dispatch, which collects the quadratic terms into a `ScalarQuadraticFunction`:

$$r_i^2 = F_{i1}^2x_1^2 + 2F_{i1}F_{i2}\,x_1x_2 + F_{i2}^2x_2^2 - 2g_i(F_{i1}x_1 + F_{i2}x_2) + g_i^2.$$

Summing over $i = 1, 2, 3$ accumulates all quadratic and linear terms into a single `ScalarQuadraticFunction` representing $\sum_i r_i^2$.

Step 3: Implicit formation of F^TF. The algebra reveals that by expanding the sum of squares, `JuMP` has implicitly formed the Gram matrix:

$$\|Fx - g\|_2^2 = x^TF^TF\,x - 2g^TF\,x + g^Tg.$$

The quadratic coefficient matrix stored in the `ScalarQuadraticFunction` is $Q = F^TF$, the linear coefficient vector is $c = -2F^Tg$, and the constant is g^Tg. These are the actual numerical

values, not symbolic expressions.

Step 4: Solver handoff. `MOSEK` natively supports quadratic objectives, so the `MOI` bridge system finds no transformation is needed. The `ScalarQuadraticFunction`—containing Q, c, and the constant—is forwarded directly to the solver's API.

Consequence. Compositions are resolved at expression-build time. There is no separate extraction phase because extraction happens incrementally during construction. But this means structure is lost: F^TF cannot be "un-formed." A conic solver that could accept $\|Fx - g\|_2$ directly as a second-order cone constraint would need to recover F from F^TF, which is not possible in general. When such a reformulation is needed, `MOI` activates a bridge, but the bridge operates on the already-formed quadratic representation rather than the original affine expression.

`CasADi` `CasADi` [24] takes a third approach. It is fundamentally a nonlinear programming tool: its primary targets are NLP solvers such as `IPOPT` [**?**], with conic capabilities (QP, SOCP) available through external backends but not as a central design focus. Internally, `CasADi` builds a symbolic expression DAG and extracts derivative information via algorithmic differentiation on the graph. For an affine expression $f(x) = Ax+b$, the Jacobian $\partial f/\partial x = A$ is the coefficient matrix, so AD-based Jacobian extraction and coefficient extraction are mathematically identical. Crucially, `CasADi` propagates sparsity symbolically through the graph before performing numerical evaluation, making it a genuine hybrid of symbolic and AD-based approaches.

This is relevant because it explicitly connects expression-graph processing to Jacobian computation, bridging the modeling and differentiation worlds. However, since `CasADi` is designed for general nonlinear problems, it applies the same AD machinery to affine expressions as to nonlinear ones—it has no specialised fast path for the purely affine case where the Jacobian is constant and the coefficients could be read off structurally rather than computed through differentiation.

`AMPL` `AMPL` [25] historically pioneered systematic coefficient extraction. Its internal representation is an expression DAG in which each node is classified by polynomial degree: constant, linear, quadratic, or general nonlinear [26]. Linear and quadratic coefficients are extracted directly from the classified nodes by walking the DAG, while the nonlinear remainder is retained as an evaluable subgraph for AD-based derivative computation. This structural decomposition allows `AMPL` to hand optimised coefficient data to linear and quadratic solvers while still supporting fully nonlinear formulations. However, `AMPL`'s extraction uses general-purpose

operations for the linear and quadratic coefficients rather than structure-aware CSR transformations, and its closed-source commercial nature has limited community development of specialised alternatives.

2.5 Computing derivatives

CHAPTER 3 A LIGHTWEIGHT COEFFICIENT EXTRACTION ENGINE

The previous chapter showed that coefficient extraction in modern modeling languages relies on generic sparse matrix multiplication—an approach that creates intermediate matrices at every node of the expression tree and treats each linear operator as an arbitrary sparse matrix. This chapter presents an alternative: a lightweight engine written in C that operates directly on CSR index arrays, avoiding intermediate matrices entirely.

3.1 Design principles

The engine is guided by three principles, each addressing a specific inefficiency identified in the previous chapter's analysis of existing systems.

Principle 1: Direct CSR rewriting Every affine atom transforms the CSR arrays `(indptr, indices, data)` of the child's Jacobian directly, rather than forming an operator matrix and composing via sparse matrix multiplication. A `sum` node merges row pointers; a `left_matmul` node applies block-diagonal dot products; an `index` node copies row segments. No intermediate sparse matrices are formed at any point.

Principle 2: Two-phase evaluation Sparsity patterns are computed once at build time (*init phase*); numerical values are filled at solve time (*eval phase*). The init phase traverses the expression tree bottom-up, determining the exact number of nonzeros in each Jacobian and allocating all arrays to their final sizes. The eval phase traverses the same tree, filling values into pre-allocated arrays without any allocation. This separation mirrors the compile-once, evaluate-many paradigm used in parametric optimisation.

Principle 3: Precomputed index mappings Where rows must be combined, reordered, or selected, a mapping from source to destination positions is precomputed during init. At eval time, the operation reduces to a single $O(\texttt{nnz})$ scatter loop. The `sum` atom's `idx_map` array (Section 3.3.2) is the prototypical example: rather than performing a sparse matrix multiplication $\mathbf{1}^T J_x$ at every evaluation, the engine scatters the child's nonzeros through a fixed map.

3.1.1 Architecture overview

The engine represents each affine expression as a node in a directed acyclic graph (DAG). Each node is a C `struct` containing:

- the node's *type* (one of the fifteen atoms in Table 3.1),
- a pair of function pointers—`jacobian_init` and `eval_jacobian`—that implement the two-phase protocol for that atom type,
- pointers to child nodes (one or two, depending on the atom),
- the Jacobian in CSR format: arrays `indptr`, `indices`, and `data`, plus dimensions,
- atom-specific auxiliary data (index maps, constant matrices, axis parameters).

Function-pointer dispatch on the node type provides polymorphism without virtual-table overhead.

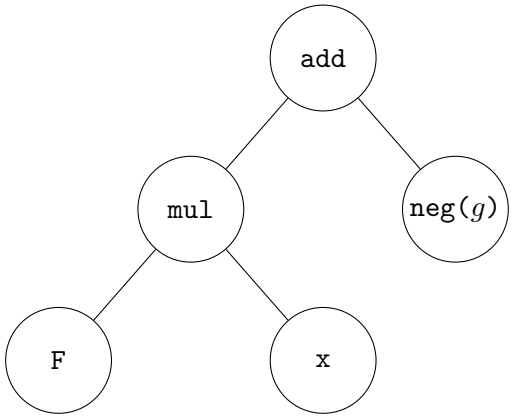
When two expressions share a common subexpression, the DAG representation allows the shared node's Jacobian to be computed once and reused by both parents. The engine tracks whether each node's Jacobian has been evaluated via a `jacobian_called` flag, avoiding redundant computation.

A *problem container* groups the objective expression and all constraint expressions, manages the global variable ordering, and stores the final assembled coefficient matrices (A, b, c) that are handed to the solver.

3.2 Worked example: tracing coefficient extraction

To build intuition before the atom-by-atom treatment, we trace the least-squares problem minimize $\|Fx - g\|_2^2$ from Chapter 2 end-to-end through the engine. After canonicalization (DCP verification, Smith form, and relaxed Smith form as described in Section 2), the conic reformulation produces the equality constraint $t = Fx - g$ linking the auxiliary variable t to the original expression. The engine must extract the coefficient matrix for this affine expression.

Expression tree after canonicalization The affine expression $Fx - g$ is represented as:



The `mul` node represents left multiplication by the constant matrix $F \in \mathbf{R}^{3\times 2}$, the `neg` node negates the constant $g \in \mathbf{R}^3$, and the `add` node sums the two children.

Init phase The engine traverses the tree bottom-up, computing sparsity patterns:

1. **Variable leaf** (x): Jacobian is I_2 (identity), so `nnz` $= 2$, `indptr` $= [0, 1, 2]$, `indices` $= [0, 1]$.
2. **`mul` node** ($F \cdot x$): The Jacobian with respect to x is F itself, a 3×2 matrix. Init determines `nnz` $= 6$ (all entries of F are nonzero) and allocates arrays of the corresponding sizes.
3. **Constant leaf** ($-g$): No variable dependence, contributes only to the constant column. Jacobian with respect to x is the 3×2 zero matrix.
4. **`add` node**: Takes the union of the children's sparsity patterns. Since the constant $-g$ contributes no variable columns, the output sparsity matches the `mul` child: `nnz` $= 6$.

After init, every node's CSR arrays are allocated to their exact final sizes. No further allocation occurs.

Eval phase A second bottom-up traversal fills in numerical values:

1. **Variable leaf**: `data` $= [1, 1]$ (identity values).
2. **`mul` node**: Applies F to the child's Jacobian via block-diagonal dot products (Section 3.3.3), writing the six entries of F into `data`.
3. **`add` node**: Sums corresponding entries. The constant offset $-g$ is added to the constant column of the output.

Result The root node's Jacobian is the coefficient matrix:

$$\begin{array}{ccc} x_1 & x_2 & 1 \\ \left[\begin{array}{cc|c} 1 & 2 & -1 \\ 3 & 4 & -2 \\ 5 & 6 & -3 \end{array}\right] & = [F \mid -g], \end{array}$$

which matches the constraint $t - Fx = -g$ from the canonicalization. The entire computation involved no sparse matrix multiplication, no intermediate matrix allocation, and no runtime sparsity discovery.

3.3 Affine atoms

Table 3.1 catalogues the fifteen affine atoms implemented in the engine. Each atom exposes two entry points: `jacobian_init`, which determines the output Jacobian's sparsity pattern once at problem-build time, and `eval_jacobian`, which fills in the numerical values each time parameters change. The table's third column summarises the key CSR manipulation performed by each atom.

Table 3.1 Catalogue of affine atoms. Each row describes one node type, its mathematical operation, and the core CSR transformation applied to the child's Jacobian during `eval_jacobian`.

Atom	Math operation	Jacobian action on CSR
`variable`	$y = x$	Identity (leaf node)
`parameter`	$y = \theta$	None (data node)
`linear_op`	$y = Ax + b$	$J = A$ (stored directly)
`add`	$y = a + b$	Union sparsity, sum values
`neg`	$y = -x$	Same sparsity, negate `data`
`sum`	$y = \sum x$ (along axis)	Merge rows via `idx_map`
`hstack`	$y = [a; b; \ldots]$	Concatenate row blocks
`index`	$y = x[\text{idx}]$	Select/reorder rows
`reshape`	$\text{reshape}(x, m, n)$	No-op (copy arrays)
`transpose`	$y = X^T$	Permute rows
`broadcast`	$(1, n) \to (m, n)$	Tile/replicate rows
`promote`	scalar $\to$ vector	Replicate single row
`trace`	$y = \mathbf{Tr}(X)$	Sum diagonal rows via `idx_map`
`diag_vec`	$v \to \mathbf{diag}(v)$	Place rows at diagonal positions
`left_matmul`	$y = A \cdot f(x)$	Block-diagonal multiply (no Kronecker)

The subsections that follow first describe the general principle of encoding linear operators directly on CSR arrays, then examine three representative atoms in detail: `sum` (Section 3.3.2),

which illustrates the `idx_map` accumulation trick; `left_matmul` (Section 3.3.3), which avoids forming a Kronecker product; and `index` (Section 3.3.4), which performs pure structural row selection with no arithmetic.

3.3.1 Direct encoding of linear operators

Rather than composing operators via sparse matrix multiplication, we keep the coefficient matrix in CSR (Compressed Sparse Row) format and directly manipulate its index arrays without forming intermediate matrices. Each linear operator is implemented as a transformation on the CSR arrays `(indptr, indices, data)`. For example, the `sum` operator collapses all rows into row 0 by setting all entries of `indptr` to $[0, \texttt{nnz}]$, effectively mapping every row index to 0 without any matrix multiplication.

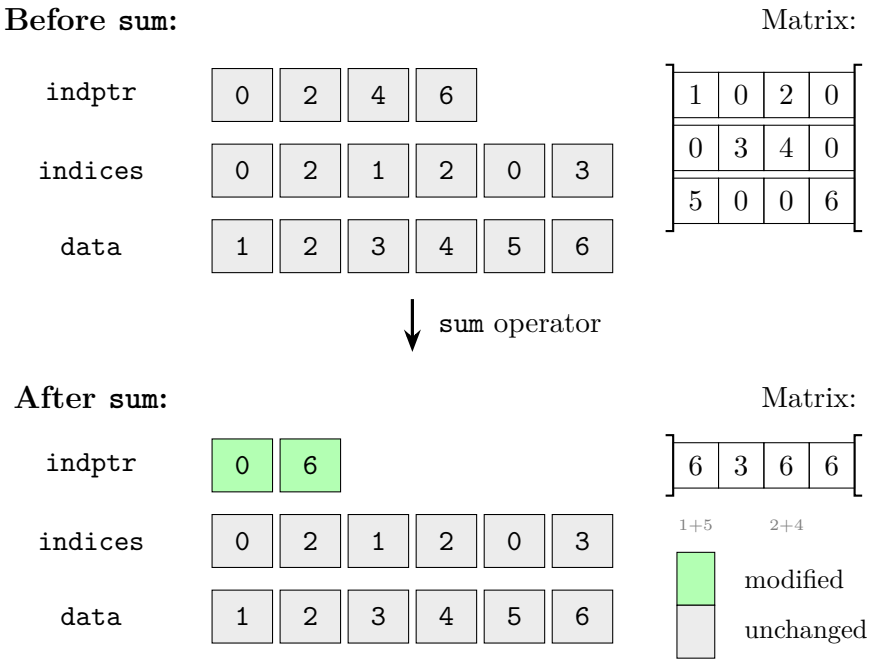


Figure 3.1 CSR representation before and after applying `sum`. The 3-row matrix collapses to 1 row by setting `indptr` $= [0, 6]$. Duplicate column indices (0 and 2) represent values that sum together. The `indices` and `data` arrays remain unchanged—no matrix multiplication required.

3.3.2 The `sum` atom and the `idx_map` trick

Summing along an axis collapses multiple rows of the child's Jacobian into fewer rows. Mathematically, for a full summation ($y = \mathbf{1}^T x$, scalar output), the Jacobian is $J_y = \mathbf{1}^T J_{\text{child}}$—every row of J_{child} is accumulated into a single output row. The naïve approach would compute

this via sparse matrix multiplication, allocating a new matrix each time. Instead, the engine precomputes a mapping from every nonzero position in the child's Jacobian to its target position in the output, then uses a simple scatter-accumulate loop at evaluation time.

Initialisation (Algorithm 1) During `jacobian_init`, the output sparsity pattern is determined by taking the union of all column indices that appear across the rows being summed. Duplicate column indices from different rows are merged into a single output entry. An array `idx_map` of length $\texttt{nnz}(J_{\text{child}})$ is then built: for each nonzero k in the child's Jacobian, `idx_map`$[k]$ stores the position in the output's `data` array where that value should be accumulated.

Algorithm 1 `sum` — Jacobian initialisation (sparsity + index map)

Require: Child Jacobian J_x in CSR format; rows to sum: $\{r_0, \ldots, r_{s-1}\}$
Ensure: Output Jacobian J with one row per output element; array `idx_map`

1: *cols* $\leftarrow$ union of column indices across summed rows of J_x
2: Sort *cols*; remove duplicates ▷ $O(\texttt{nnz} \log \texttt{nnz})$
3: Set J.`indptr`, J.`indices` from *cols*
4: Build reverse map `col_to_pos`[ ]: for each unique column c at position p, set `col_to_pos`$[c] \leftarrow p$
5: **for** each nonzero k in J_x (across summed rows) **do**
6: `idx_map`$[k] \leftarrow$ `col_to_pos`$[J_x.\texttt{indices}[k]]$
7: **end for**

Evaluation (Algorithm 2) At each parameter update, `eval_jacobian` zeroes the output values and then scatters the child's nonzeros through the precomputed map. The loop body is a single indexed addition per nonzero—no sorting, no allocation, and no matrix multiply.

Algorithm 2 `sum` — Jacobian evaluation

Require: Child Jacobian J_x (values updated); precomputed `idx_map`
Ensure: Output Jacobian J with accumulated values

1: $J.\texttt{data} \leftarrow \mathbf{0}$
2: **for** $k = 0$ **to** $\texttt{nnz}(J_x) - 1$ **do**
3: $J.\texttt{data}[\texttt{idx_map}[k]]$ += $J_x.\texttt{data}[k]$
4: **end for**

Complexity Initialisation costs $O(\texttt{nnz} \log \texttt{nnz})$ (dominated by the sort) and runs once. Evaluation costs $O(\texttt{nnz})$ with a single pass over the child's nonzeros. While sparse matrix multiplication $\mathbf{1}^T J_x$ is also $O(\texttt{nnz})$ in principle, it must allocate a new result matrix, compute

its sparsity pattern, and sort indices at every call—overhead that the `idx_map` approach eliminates entirely. Figure 3.1 illustrates the CSR transformation for a concrete example.

3.3.3 The `left_matmul` atom and Kronecker avoidance

Left multiplication computes $Y = A\,X$ where $A \in \mathbf{R}^{m\times n}$ is a constant (or parameter) matrix and $X \in \mathbf{R}^{n\times p}$ is the child expression. Writing the operation in vectorised form gives

$$\mathbf{vec}(Y) = (I_p \otimes A)\ \mathbf{vec}(X), \tag{3.1}$$

so the Jacobian with respect to $\mathbf{vec}(X)$ is the block-diagonal matrix $I_p \otimes A$ of size $mp \times np$. Forming this Kronecker product explicitly would require storing $p \cdot \mathtt{nnz}(A)$ entries in the best case; worse, composing it with the child's Jacobian via sparse matrix multiplication is $O(p^2 \cdot \mathtt{nnz}(A))$ in general.

The engine avoids the Kronecker product entirely by exploiting the block-diagonal structure. It stores only A (of size $m \times n$) and applies it independently to each of the p column-blocks of the child's Jacobian. The computation is carried out in CSC (Compressed Sparse Column) format, because the child's Jacobian columns each decompose naturally into p consecutive blocks of n rows.

Initialisation During `jacobian_init`, the child's Jacobian sparsity is converted to CSC. For each column j and each block $b \in \{0, \ldots, p-1\}$, the engine identifies which rows of A have overlapping column support with the child's nonzeros in block b. These overlaps determine the output sparsity without ever forming $I_p \otimes A$.

Evaluation (Algorithm 3) At each parameter update, the child's Jacobian values are converted to CSC, then each output nonzero is computed as a sparse dot product of a row of A with the corresponding block-slice of the child's column.

Complexity Let $\bar{k}$ denote the average number of nonzeros per column of J_{child} within a single block. Each output nonzero requires a sparse dot product of cost at most $O(\mathtt{nnz_row}(A) + \bar{k})$. The total work is therefore $O(\mathtt{nnz}(J) \cdot (\mathtt{nnz_row}(A) + \bar{k}))$, which for typical sparse problems is far smaller than the $O(p^2 \cdot \mathtt{nnz}(A))$ cost of forming and multiplying the Kronecker product.

Algorithm 3 `left_matmul` — Jacobian evaluation (block-diagonal multiply)

Require: Constant matrix $A \in \mathbf{R}^{m \times n}$; child Jacobian J_x in CSC with p column-blocks of n rows; precomputed output sparsity J in CSC
Ensure: Output Jacobian J with filled values

Convert J_x values from CSR to CSC ▷ pattern already fixed
for each column j of J **do**
  for each block $b = 0, \ldots, p-1$ **do**
    $S \leftarrow$ nonzeros of J_x column j in rows $[b \cdot n,\ (b+1) \cdot n)$
    for each output nonzero $(b \cdot m + i,\ j)$ in J **do**
      $J.\texttt{data}[\cdot] \leftarrow \text{sparse_dot}(A[i, :],\ S)$
    end for
  end for
end for
Convert J values from CSC to CSR

3.3.4 The `index` atom and structural row selection

Indexing selects a subset of elements from the child expression: $y = x[\text{indices}]$. Its Jacobian is a row-selection matrix P whose rows are drawn from the identity—row i of P is row indices$[i]$ of I. Since the child's Jacobian is stored in CSR, selecting rows amounts to copying contiguous segments of the `indices` and `data` arrays guided by `indptr`. No arithmetic is performed at all.

Initialisation (Algorithm 4) During `jacobian_init`, the output Jacobian's sparsity pattern is constructed by copying the column-index segment of each selected row from the child's Jacobian. The row pointer array `indptr` is built incrementally.

Algorithm 4 `index` — Jacobian initialisation (structural copy)

Require: Child Jacobian J_x in CSR; selection array $\texttt{idx}[0 \ldots k-1]$
Ensure: Output Jacobian J in CSR with selected rows

$J.\texttt{indptr}[0] \leftarrow 0$
for $i = 0$ **to** $k - 1$ **do**
  $r \leftarrow \texttt{idx}[i]$ ▷ source row in J_x
  $\ell \leftarrow J_x.\texttt{indptr}[r+1] - J_x.\texttt{indptr}[r]$
  Copy $J_x.\texttt{indices}[J_x.\texttt{indptr}[r] \ldots J_x.\texttt{indptr}[r] + \ell)$ into $J.\texttt{indices}[J.\texttt{indptr}[i] \ldots]$
  $J.\texttt{indptr}[i+1] \leftarrow J.\texttt{indptr}[i] + \ell$
end for
$J.\texttt{nnz} \leftarrow J.\texttt{indptr}[k]$

Evaluation (Algorithm 5) At each parameter update, `eval_jacobian` copies the `data` segments for the same selected rows. The sparsity pattern is identical to the child's selected rows, so only values move.

Algorithm 5 `index` — Jacobian evaluation (value copy)

Require: Child Jacobian J_x (values updated); selection array $\texttt{idx}[0 \dots k-1]$; output Jacobian J (pattern fixed)
Ensure: Output Jacobian J with copied values
1: **for** $i = 0$ **to** $k - 1$ **do**
2: $r \leftarrow \texttt{idx}[i]$
3: $\ell \leftarrow J.\texttt{indptr}[i+1] - J.\texttt{indptr}[i]$
4: Copy $J_x.\texttt{data}[J_x.\texttt{indptr}[r] \dots J_x.\texttt{indptr}[r] + \ell)$ into $J.\texttt{data}[J.\texttt{indptr}[i] \dots]$
5: **end for**

Complexity Both initialisation and evaluation cost $O\Big(\sum_{i=0}^{k-1} \texttt{nnz}(\text{row}_{\texttt{idx}[i]})\Big)$, proportional to the total number of nonzeros in the selected rows. The operation involves no arithmetic—only `memcpy` calls—making it one of the cheapest atoms in the engine.

The preceding atom deep-dives illustrate the common pattern: each atom transforms the child's CSR arrays directly, using precomputed index mappings to eliminate runtime allocation and sparsity discovery. The remaining sections address the system-level concerns that complete the engine design.

3.4 Memory management

The two-phase design described in Section 3.1 enables tight control over memory allocation. This section describes the four techniques the engine uses to minimise memory overhead.

Exact-size allocation The init phase determines the exact number of nonzeros in every node's Jacobian before any numerical computation occurs. All `malloc` calls therefore allocate arrays of exactly the required size—no over-allocation, no reallocation, and no amortised-doubling strategies. For a tree with N nodes, init performs at most $3N$ allocations (one each for `indptr`, `indices`, and `data` per node), and eval performs zero.

Affine Jacobian caching Nodes whose children are all constants (no variable or parameter dependence) produce Jacobians that never change. The engine detects such nodes during init and marks them as *cached*: their `eval_jacobian` is called once, and subsequent evaluations skip them entirely. In typical problems, constant subexpressions (data matrices, fixed offsets)

constitute a significant fraction of the tree, so caching eliminates a proportional share of eval-time work.

No Python object overhead Because the engine is implemented in C, there is no `scipy.sparse` object creation, no Python reference counting or garbage collection pressure during evaluation, and no format-conversion copies between CSR and CSC. Each Jacobian is stored as three raw C arrays and a set of dimension fields. The total per-node overhead is a fixed-size `struct` plus the three arrays, compared to the multiple Python objects, type metadata, and indirection layers in a `scipy.sparse.csr_matrix`.

Memory footprint analysis The engine's total memory consumption for a single expression tree is:

$$M = \sum_{i=1}^{N} \Big((n_i{+}1)\cdot\texttt{sizeof(int)} + \texttt{nnz}_i \cdot (\texttt{sizeof(int)} + \texttt{sizeof(double)}) \Big) + N\cdot\texttt{sizeof(expr)},$$

where n_i is the number of rows and $\texttt{nnz}_i$ the number of nonzeros in node i's Jacobian. In `CVXPY`'s approach, each sparse matrix multiplication at node i temporarily allocates an additional result matrix, so the peak memory includes both the child's matrix and the product. The engine avoids this by writing directly into the pre-allocated output, so peak memory equals the sum above with no temporary overhead.

3.5 Parameter handling

When a problem contains parameters (symbolic placeholders whose numerical values change between solves), the engine must update the coefficient matrices without repeating the init phase. The two-phase architecture makes this straightforward.

Parameter lifecycle Parameters are registered during problem construction via `register_params`, which associates each parameter node in the expression tree with a pointer to the user-supplied value storage. When the user updates parameter values and requests a new solve, `update_params` copies the new values into the parameter nodes.

Lazy refresh via `jacobian_called` Each node carries a Boolean flag `jacobian_called`. After `update_params` is called, the engine resets this flag on every node that depends (transitively) on a changed parameter. The subsequent eval traversal then recomputes only the

affected nodes. Nodes that depend solely on constants retain their cached Jacobians and are not revisited.

Direct re-traversal Unlike `CVXPY`'s tensor-based parametric approach, which stores a three-dimensional structure mapping each parameter to its coefficient contributions, the engine simply re-traverses the expression tree with the new parameter values. This avoids the storage overhead of the tensor representation and reuses the same tree-walking infrastructure used for the initial evaluation.

Contrast with the tensor approach `CVXPY`'s `TensorView` maintains a dictionary of dictionaries: for each variable, for each parameter, a separate sparse matrix. For problems with p parameters and v variables, this multiplies the storage by up to $p \cdot v$. The engine's approach stores only one Jacobian per node regardless of the number of parameters. The trade-off is that a parameter update requires a full eval traversal rather than a single sparse matrix substitution, but since eval is dominated by $O(\texttt{nnz})$ scatter and copy operations, this cost is modest in practice.

CHAPTER 4 BENCHMARK RESULTS

CHAPTER 5 Benchmark results

CHAPTER 6 CONCLUSION

Texte / Text.

6.1 Synthèse des travaux / Summary of Works

Texte / Text.

6.2 Limitations de la solution proposée / Limitations

6.3 Améliorations futures / Future Research

Texte / Text.

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APPENDIX A DÉMO

Texte de l'annexe A. Remarquez que la phrase précédente se termine par une lettre majuscule suivie d'un point. On indique explicitement cette situation à LaTeX afin que ce dernier ajuste correctement l'espacement entre le point final de la phrase et le début de la phrase suivante.

APPENDIX B ENCORE UNE ANNEXE / ANOTHER APPENDIX

Texte de l'annexe B en mode «landscape».

APPENDIX C UNE DERNIÈRE ANNEXE / THE LAST APPENDIX

Texte de l'annexe C.